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For more information about our processes, please view the documents below:

-  [Fraud and verification – applicants' guide](#) (547.35 KB)
-  [Similarity – applicants' guide](#) (210.52 KB)
-  [Similarity – applicant FAQs](#) (264.5 KB)

ESSAY 1

Every weekend on vacation, I like to run for an hour on the trails of Karura forest at the heart of Nairobi. It is a world of difference from the grass field on campus. It represents the best and worst of my country and reminds me of the influence the city has had on my values and passions.

When I run through the forest, I feel that constant drive to keep going that exists in the Kenyan psyche amidst the odds. We love to run not just on the tracks but towards every goal we put our minds to. On weekday mornings, you see many of our people walking briskly along the Mombasa road to the central business district or battling through frustrating traffic jams in a matatu (local public buses). We wake up the next day and do it all over again. We believe that the journey we take towards anything must be done with patient haste. It is in this spirit that makes me love cross country contests and through these contests, I have learnt the strength of cautious focus and taking one step at a time towards any goal.

As I run through the forest, I remember why we fight against those who will steal and destroy the diversity that defines my city and country. As a people, we are from different tribes and nationalities. Whether it is leaders trying to stoke tribal sentiments for parochial gains or poachers and loggers destroying the forest and animals, I am reminded of the need to preserve our human and natural diversity. Diversity in our foods, clothes, languages and even beliefs. More importantly, we embrace nature as an essential part of a modern city. The city is the few in the world that is a neighbor to a wild National Park. When I joined the Hog Charge challenge, it was a personal goal to conserve that character of my city. To keep the green beauty of my city and follow in the footsteps of Wangari Maathai, who, I believe, saw the same beauty in our country.

On the trail, I appreciate the principle of giving back. I have known a friend in the park for the past four years. His name is Ranger Omolo. His decade-long dedication to the protection of the forest amidst scarce resources is admirable. As I jog through the plush woods and dangerous terrain, I am reminded that the real heroes are not those who stand in the spotlight of the press or spectators but those who seek to do the right thing even when no one is watching. Mr. Omolo is one of such heroes who gives me faith in the value of giving back. He taught me the importance of diligence and excellence no matter the role I find myself in. Whether it is as a student leader or as a teacher in rural classrooms, I ensure the same dedication and excellence is given.

On those weekends on the trail, I enjoy the value of friendship. Sometimes on my run, I enjoy the company of some monkeys swinging alongside me in the trees on both sides of the trail. Other times I meet people who join me to help them run and encourage them to press forward when the going gets tough. The symbiotic feeling that all else around us is important for our growth and betterment, whether it's a person or animal is a belief that will stay with me as I pursue my dream as an engineer. I am an influence to my community and environment and I will do my best to maintain that sanctity of that relationship.

ESSAY 2

My grandmother hovers over the stove flame, fanning it as she melodically hums Kikuyu spirituals. She kneads the dough and places it on the stove, her veins throbbing with every movement: a living masterpiece painted by a life of poverty and motherhood. The air becomes thick with smoke and I am soon forced out of the walls of the mud-brick house while she laughs. As for me, I wander down to the small stream at the ridge on the farm's edge, remembering my father's stories of rising up early to feed the cows and my mother's memories of the sweat on her brow from hours of picking coffee at a local plantation.

Life here juxtaposes itself profoundly against the life I live in America; the scourge of poverty and flickering prosperity that never seem to coalesce. But these are the two worlds I have inherited, and my existence in one is not possible without the other. At the stream, I recollect my other life beyond this place. In America, I watch my father come home every night, beaten yet resilient from another day of hard work on the road. He sits me and my sister down, and though weary-eyed, he manages the soft smile I know him for and asks about our day.

My sister is quick to oblige, speaking wildly of learning and mischief. In that moment, I realize that she is too young to remember our original home: the old dust of barren apartment walls and the constant roar outside of life in the nighttime.

Soon after, I find myself lying in bed, my thoughts and the soft throb of my head the only audible things in the room. I ponder whether my parents — dregs floating across a diasporic sea before my time — would have imagined their sacrifices for us would come with sharp pains in their backs and newfound worries, tear-soaked nights and early mornings. But, it is too much to process. Instead, I dream of them and the future I will build with the tools they have given me.

Realizing I have mused far too long by the water's edge, I begin to make my way back to the house. The climb up the ridge is taxing, so I carefully grip the soil beneath me, feeling its warmth surge between my fingers. Finally, I see my younger cousins running around barefoot endlessly and I decide to join their game of soccer, but they all laugh at the awkwardness of the ball between my feet. They play, scream and chant, fully unaware of the world beyond this village or even Nairobi, but I cannot blame them. My iPhone fascinates them and they ask to see my braces, intently questioning how many "shillings" they cost. I open my mouth to satisfy their curiosity, but my grandmother calls out, and we all rush to see what she has made.

When I return, the chapatis are neatly stacked on one another, golden-brown disks of sweet bread that are the completion of every Kenyan meal. Before my grandmother can ridicule me in a torrent of Kikuyu, I grab a chapati and escape to find a patch of silky grass, where I take my first bite. Each mouthful is a reminder that my time here will not last forever, and that my success or

failure will become a defining example for my sister and relatives.

The rift between high school and college is wide, but it is one I must cross for those who have carried me to this point. The same hope that carried my parents over an ocean of uncertainty is now my fuel for the journey toward my future, and I go forward with the radical idea that I, too, can make it. Savoring each bite, I listen to the sound of neighbors calling out and children chasing a dog ridden with fleas, letting the cool heat cling to my skin.

Essay 3

Whispers broke out in the crowd, the elders staring at me in disbelief, and the youth barely hiding their amusement.

Nevertheless, I stuttered throughout the rest of my dedication and rushed back to my seat, scattered claps following in my wake. I was furious with the crowd for laughing at me, and with myself for giving them a good reason to. The rest of the ceremony went in a blur. At tea time, I dragged myself to the smoky kitchen, trying to ignore the loud whispers and sniggers that followed me. Aunt Chelimo stood up to stretch herself just as I got in, and when she caught my eye, she said, tongue-in-cheek, "Ehe, the city girl who cannot speak Kalenjin, even at her grandmother's memorial!"

In the uncomfortable silence that ensued, Mum sieved the tea, quietly handing the thermos flask over to me to take to the Elders' tent. My great uncle, Kipchirchir, looked at me suspiciously as I approached and talked to me in Kalenjin. I replied apologetically that I couldn't understand. With a morose shake of his head, he turned back to the elders, and said in Swahili, "A tree with no roots."

A tree with no roots. I left that ceremony feeling worse than I had ever felt in my life. On our painfully silent journey back home that evening, my mind wandered back to the older days; Kalenjin was initially the secret code, spoken by my parents when they wanted to have a confidential conversation, while the languages of instruction to us were English and Swahili. I was I when Mum attempted to teach me Kalenjin, but my preteen self so stubbornly refused to cooperate that she gave up on me. My flawed reasoning was that we were 'urban', and therefore had Swahili for 'authenticity'. During various family gatherings and trips to Sangurur, our home village, I always felt a distinct desire to understand the peculiar pronunciations and intonations of Kalenjin, but I pushed it to my subconscious. However, that memorial day, it refused to stay there. As I stayed awake in my bed that night, feeling guilty for desecrating my grandmother's memory with my ignorance, and being a stranger to my own tribal tongue, I remembered that merely having guilty feelings would not right my wrongs. It was time to change. I needed to learn Kalenjin.

From that month onwards, I tried different methods of learning, from listening to Kalenjin radio stations and putting traditional music on my playlist (this amused my friends), to instructing my parents to speak in Kalenjin only, with necessary translations. I even started reading the Bible in Kalenjin, and keeping a diary of the new words I learnt daily. Performing as a soloist in a traditional Kalenjin song during my final music assessment in High School imparted in me knowledge of our colorful traditional garb, dance and vocal ornamentation. It has not been easy; many times I feel ashamed in holding a conversation with my fluent cousins, uncles and aunts in the broken Kalenjin I have learnt. Nevertheless, I try, and I have noticed that things I used to see with indifference, such as mursik, our traditional drink, and Kalenjin proverbs, poems and sayings, are becoming meaningful to

That night after the memorial, I resolved to learn Kalenjin in a bid to prove myself; to show that I was worthy of my second name. But since then, I have realized that learning my native language is not a competition, it is a journey of self-awareness and appreciation of traditions that have been in my family for generations.

I may never pass the litmus test of Kalenjin fluency, but this tree won't stop growing its roots.

***Gogo-Grandmother**

Essay 4

I'm in a place I never expected to be, doing something I never dreamt I would have enough courage to do so. The paralyzing cold is simply the beginning of my many sufferings. It's dark and only with the help of a measly head torch am I able to vaguely make out my boot-clad feet taking one step, then another, and another.

We stop and I feel around what I presume is a rock. I take a slow, carefully calculated seat and reach out my hand for the steaming cup I'm offered; then I take the slightest sip and it burns. I feel every last drop and silently rejoice as it travels down to the rest of my body. It's almost too soon when I realize I have to get back up; I can't let the cold catch up to me. I have to keep going. So, I slowly get back up, get in line, and continue the monotony I've endured for three days. I take one step, then another, and another.

Amid all the reminders to keep my eyes open and just keep going, it hits me: I'm on Mt. Kilimanjaro, a few kilometres from summiting the tallest free-standing mountain in the world. How did I get here?

From the moment I could hold a proper conversation, it's been common knowledge that anything is possible if you put your mind to it'. Yet, by the time I was thirteen 'anything' was reduced to a small list including, but not limited to: getting good grades, playing a piano piece faultlessly twice in a row and perfecting my scrambled eggs. The thought of climbing a mountain didn't even occur to me. It wasn't until I started preparing for the five-day excursion, four years later that I realized how vital this 'mind' everyone keeps raving about actually is.

In the end, I didn't summit. The altitude sickness got the best of me and before I knew it, I had to start descending. Nonetheless, I learned a lot about myself and instead of beating myself up about not getting to the top, I gave myself a pat on the back for surpassing the 5,000m point and pressing on even though I was suffering.

Many, including my mother, asked why I would want to experience such a thing and in hindsight, all of them have never climbed a mountain, so I shouldn't have expected them to understand. If they had endured what I did, they would have an entirely different outlook on what it means to have a positive mindset. On that mountain, you have no choice but to keep putting one foot in front of the other. The only way to achieve that is to stay positive and push yourself to keep moving.

After I returned home, I had a different approach to handling various situations. I became more aware of the fact that everything happens one step at a time, not all at once. Even if I worry myself over how much work I have to do during a particular week, I still have to take it one day at a time.

I came to realize that it's not only on a mountain that positivity exercises its power. In the gym, I never finish that last set of squats if I don't motivate myself to do them all. The first time I changed my little brother's diaper, it was a mess and even after my father scared me by telling me not to break his toes, I approached it with a determined attitude and I can proudly say that I am a diaper-changing expert. Though a positive mindset wasn't new to me, I had a better understanding of how I used it to accomplish goals in the past and how I could better exercise it to succeed in the future. I think the toughest times in life are those that build us up higher than we were when they tore us down. Seeing the negative side of every situation can be more trying than the circumstance itself.

In life, just like on that frosty summit night, you have to tell yourself to get back up, even when you think you can't handle it. After all, with a positive mind, EVERYTHING is possible. All you have to do it take one step, then another, and another.

ESSAY 5

It was on Monday 8th October 2012 when my sister and I were sent home for not paying our school fees. My mum sent us to my dad's shop since it was his turn to pay for our school fees. When we got there, he gave me my fees but told my sister to drop out of school and cook for us. I remember the devastation on her face amidst her pleadings to my father but he didn't change his mind.

At that moment, I felt, for the first time, anger or even rage and a sense of injustice done. She was on the verge of sitting her national exam. How can he just tell her to drop out at this point? I consoled my sister and gave her my fees so she could pay hers, my mother paid mine later on. It was this incident that opened my eyes to see the injustices men in my community commit toward women.

I come from a small, illiterate and economically deprived village (Moyale) in the northern part of Kenya. Women are seen as second-class citizens and they are expected to treat men as small gods. The situation is so oppressive that mothers worship their sons.

On the other hand, a girl child is considered bad luck and the importance of women is confined to the

domestic space: raising children, taking care of household affairs and grooming their young daughters to find husbands. As boys, our dream was to grow, acquire many camels and wives so we can be respected, education was never a part. Neither of my parents attended a school. It was in such an environment that made it difficult for many of us to aspire to attend higher education. Moreover, it even made it worse for girls to dream of any form of education.

On 4th November 2012, a group of men including our tribe leader (The Ugas) came to our house. He came to discuss something important with my father. Right after, my father called the family together and announced that my sister was to be married off to the Ugas' son (who was as old as his father). My mom and sisters could not speak nor defend themselves since it was regarded as an insult to the tribe. My sister who was to sit for a national exam in a month's time was to be married in two weeks. All her effort and hard work would go to waste I tried to convince my dad otherwise but my efforts were futile. Worst of all, after three years of their marriage, my sister was divorced and left to care for three children alone.

It is these personal experiences that have informed my attitude towards women. I decided that I could be the change to this unfair tradition in my own small way. So, later in high school, I formed an organization called 'Elimu Kwa Wasichana' (education to girls) where we tutor girls in all primary school subjects. We also invite guests who advise them on issues related to menstruation and pregnancy (since my tribe frown on maternity hospitals). We have partnered with Child Fund Kenya where we are able to provide sanitary

pads for these teenage girls. Through my organization, we act as translators and the girls and women are able to report abuses to the police because most of them cannot speak Kiswahili.

I feel that my community should embrace women and give them equal opportunity to realize their dreams. After all, they are our mothers, sisters and friends. I look forward to partnering with more organization in which we can give a voice to the needs and issues of women not only in my community but also the world at large. Together we can make the world a better place for women. To my village I am not yet done with you!!

ESSAY 6

I was only four years old when I experienced my first major culture shock.

I had not only been separated from my home but also from my dear mother and loving grandparents. Everything seemed so bleak.

I remember arriving in Nairobi for the first time, disoriented and confused. My state of normalcy had been completely disrupted and I harbored a fear of the uncertain future that lay ahead.

I was a stranger - a stranger even to my siblings. As I could only speak my native language, the first few months with them were particularly hard due to lack of proper communication and frequent misunderstandings. It was bothersome having to use a translator around anytime I wanted to communicate with the people I loved. Moreover, the disconnection between us was huge: I was used to

playing with mud and twigs whilst they were used to playing with colorful toys and dolls. I felt inferior but worse off, I felt alone. I was no longer in the comfort of my grandparent's care. I was no longer home - no longer safe and secure. This feeling of alienation continued to increase as the days went by and eventually, I started spending more time in isolation.

The most debilitating days were the nostalgia-filled ones. On those days, my life would come to a stop and all I could think about was my grandparents and my mother. Those were the days when it all seemed insurmountable.

Five years passed before I got the chance to see my mother again. It was during my grandfather's funeral (not the ideal moment for a reunion). I could barely recognize her: she wasn't the same but neither was I. Simply put, she didn't feel like home anymore. But I didn't blame her and still don't. In front of her wasn't the son she had raised. I had morphed into someone else - an emotional recluse - apathetic towards and dismissive of all that had been important to me. Why? Because to a five-year-old Brandon, a path of self neglect and solitude in the name of 'self-reliance' and 'independence' had appeared the best way to survive in a world that was so different and foreign.

It was four years later, however, when I truly hit rock-bottom due to my grandmother passing on. I was utterly shaken. If the road had seemed bleak before, it now seemed unnavigable. My main foundation, my main source of strength was no more. I was alone and scared again - just like my four-year-old self. A world without my grandmother seemed impossibly desolate; nothing felt like home.

'You've got to move on', 'She's at a better place'. 'You've got to be strong'. All those words felt empty and bare but the more I pondered on them, the more the pain and bitterness subsided. Looking back, I now realize that my grandmother's death sparked the most significant period of growth in my life. Gradually, I started developing a new mindset and settling into this strange place I'd deemed not fit to be my home for the previous 9 years. 'This is what my grandmother would have wanted,' I told myself. I wanted to regain the happiness and tranquility that I felt before I was introduced to this strange new world.

With hindsight, I realize that what I was truly afraid of was change. I was afraid of changing when I moved to Nairobi and again was afraid of change when my grandmother died. The only difference is that the first time I rejected it but the second time I embraced it.

Because of my newly found strength and ability to adapt, moments of tremendous change no longer instill fear in me. For example, transitioning from the Kenyan Curriculum of Education to the British Curriculum of Education was not as difficult as I thought it would be as I was able to adapt better and integrate myself into the community well.

My perception of change has now changed and I now appreciate it as a necessary component of growth.